



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Liberty Tree Academy
School Website: <https://ltaeagles.org/>

December 27, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Liberty Tree Academy Co 80831 (LTA) presents itself as a tuition-free, K–12 charter school grounded in a traditional American, liberal-arts inspired program that leverages Hillsdale College's K–12 curriculum and a mix of direct instruction, Socratic inquiry, and rhetoric-focused activities. Public materials emphasize virtues such as truth, character, and civic virtue, plus a commitment to a content-rich, liberal-arts education with an explicit emphasis on the liberal arts, classical language study (notably Latin), and a strong history/geography/civics backbone. The school also highlights Socratic dialogue in the upper grades and a direct-instruction approach in the lower grades, with explicit attention to memory work, singing, and the cultivation of wonder.

Overall, by the classical-school rubric, Liberty Tree Academy lands in the SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL category. The school clearly adopts several core classical elements (grammar, logic, rhetoric; history-centric study; liberal-arts focus; Socratic inquiry in the upper grades; Latin study; character formation). However, explicit, recurring references to liturgical/theological foundations, a fully developed "great-books" program or explicit Great Conversation framing, and a comprehensive articulation of the living-faculty model (as opposed to teacher-student roles) are not as strongly evidenced in the public materials available via the crawl. The aggregate assessment hence balances strong classical cues with some gaps relative to a fully articulated, iconically "classical" program.

Executive summary — Element-by-Element snapshot: - Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL - Curriculum: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Pedagogy: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Faculty: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL - Parents & Community: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What would move the needle: explicit theology and liturgical/community practices; explicit Great Books/Great Conversation framing; a more explicit "living curriculum" conception for faculty; stronger, visible parent-formation and co-teaching partnerships; and a publicly stated emphasis on restorative "scholé" style elements (contemplation, memory, quiet time) to complement Socratic and active-learning modes.

The following evaluation draws on two sources: - Knowledge-base rubric and positive/negative keyword indicators for classical education (the Six Essential Elements). See the lexicon for classically oriented keywords (e.g., truth, virtue, grammar/logic/rhetoric, great books, Socratic, scholé, wonder, liturgy, theology, etc.) and their positive/negative signals. - School-specific crawl material for Liberty Tree Academy (public-facing content on ltaeagles.org and related pages/contracts), including explicit statements about mission, program, curriculum, and pedagogical approaches. Examples include statements about truth, traditional American education, character and civic virtue, Hillsdale-based curriculum, the use of Socratic Method in upper grades, and a lower-school emphasis on direct instruction and class discussions.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence

- Public materials emphasize truth-seeking, moral character, and civic virtue as central aims. For example, the site frames the education as one that “seeks the truth” and aims to “cultivate character” in a traditional American context, with emphasis on self-governance and liberty as guiding ends.
- The charter contract and mission statements likewise foreground moral character and civic virtue within a classical framework.
- The Hillsdale-based curriculum and classical language study (Latin) point to a historically grounded, if secularized, classical formation rather than explicit liturgical or theological practice.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present in public materials: truth; virtue; moral character; civic virtue; traditional American education (mapped to “transcendental moral realism” and “virtue” in the lexicon).
 - Negative keywords: none clearly evident in public materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or morally neutral framing). The lexicon flags these as negative signals, but they do not prominently appear in LTA’s public content.
- Why this rating
 - The presence of truth and virtue signals alignment with transcendental/moral-realism commitments. The absence of explicit liturgical/theological grounding and liturgical practices reduces it from fully “Classical” on this axis to “Somewhat Classical.” The school clearly leans into a character-formation project and a moral frame, which are central to the classical rubric, even if not overtly theological.
- Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school’s mission centers on forming virtuous, self-governing citizens and preserving liberty, a telos oriented toward human flourishing through a liberal-arts formation, rather than job-preparation alone. This is explicit in mission statements and contract language.
 - The public materials frame education as formation (virtue, character) and emphasize a real conception of truth, goodness, and beauty as accessible through a liberal-arts curriculum.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: formation; virtue; liberal arts; telos; pursuit of truth/good/beautiful (explicit framing in the hillsdale-based materials and mission).
 - Negative keywords: none evident (no “workforce-ready” framing or purely utilitarian descriptors).
- Why this rating
 - The school’s stated aims clearly align with classical purposes of education: forming virtuous, wise, and free citizens via a liberal-arts formation, not primarily job prep. The combination of tradition, moral formation, and liberal-arts core supports CLASSICAL status.
- Rating: CLASSICAL

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The curriculum features liberal-arts primaries (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Latin, and a strong emphasis on history/geography/economics/civics, with a Hillsdale-based K–12 program and a Core Knowledge/Well-Ordered Language orientation. This is documented in curriculum materials and contract language.
 - The site emphasizes history and civics integration, and the use of a traditional, content-rich approach rather than a project-first approach. Public materials note direct instruction in lower grades and Socratic/seminar approaches in upper grades, consistent with classical pedagogy but with a mixed-structure in practice.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis

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- Positive keywords present: liberal arts; grammar; logic; rhetoric; Latin; history/geography/economics/civics; Core Knowledge; Well-Ordered Language; Singapore Math; Socratic method (upper grades).
 - Negative keywords: The explicit Great Books/Great Conversation framing is not clearly present in public language; the materials also do not foreground a fully “Great Books” syllabus. The absence of explicit Great Books coverage reduces it from full CLASSICAL to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL on this axis.
 - Why this rating
 - While the curriculum contains core classical elements (grammar/logical/rhetorical training; Latin; liberal-arts orientation; history-centric approach), the lack of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis and some traditional Great-Books signaling lowers it to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL in this rubric.
 - Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Lower grades emphasize direct instruction and constant class discussion, consistent with rigorous foundational work. Upper grades feature Socratic discussion and seminars, with opportunities for rhetoric and public speaking. The materials also describe engaging activities and memory-oriented learning in early years (singing and chant-like repetition).
 - The public materials align with the classical pedagogy spectrum: a blend of direct instruction (Scholé-like contemplation not explicitly named) and Socratic/seminar-based inquiry in upper grades.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: Socratic method; memory work/recitation; chanting; seminar; discourse; rhetoric; structured questioning; direct instruction; wonder (in some curricular descriptions).
 - Negative keywords: no explicit emphasis on purely experiential learning or project-based-only pedagogy; however, the absence of a fully-Scholé oriented, contemplative schedule keeps the score from CLASSICAL on this axis. The lexicon flags “restful learning” and “Scholé” as positive indicators; explicit affirmative labeling of Scholé-friendly days is not shown in the public materials.
- Why this rating
 - The school presents a mixed pedagogy with both Socratic/logic-driven upper grades and direct-instruction lower grades, plus memory-oriented elements, which maps onto SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully classical pedagogy that would foreground contemplative/restful, scholé-style days throughout. The presence of Socratic and rhetoric emphasis in upper grades anchors it toward classical, but the overall pedagogy is not uniformly Scholé-forward.
- Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Element 5: School Faculty — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - Public-facing materials identify administrators (Headmaster, Assistant Headmaster) and staff; testimonials praise teachers and leadership; the site highlights a professional, structured leadership team. The content does not prominently advertise a formal “living curriculum” portrait of teacher-mentors, though it emphasizes teachers’ roles in direct instruction, Socratic discussion, and student engagement.
 - The contract and governance materials imply accountability and professional staff, but do not present a distinct “faculty-as-living-curriculum” or “portrait of teacher” framework in public materials.
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis

- Positive keywords present: model teachers and mentors; teachers as a core of the school (conceptually aligned with “living curriculum” in classical pedagogy). The site uses “Headmaster” and “Assistant Headmaster” with visible leadership. However, explicit language about the faculty as the living curriculum or portraits of teacher/student ideals is not overt.
- Negative keywords: none explicit in the public materials (no denigration of teachers; no “facilitators” role language that would signal a non-classical approach). The lexicon lists potential negative signals (e.g., “certification-driven jargon without classical context”), which are not evident here.
- Why this rating
 - There is clear evidence of a seasoned faculty structure and leadership, but the public materials do not foreground the “living curriculum” image or the full portrait-language the classical rubric sometimes expects. As a result, the faculty category sits in SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than clearly CLASSICAL.
- Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Element 6: School Parents and Community — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Evidence
 - The school emphasizes an engaged, open environment for families, with enrollment processes that welcome families; there is mention of parent involvement in the form of volunteering and district oversight expectations in the charter documentation. The enrollment pages and testimonials convey a family-inclusive environment.
 - The charter contract references parent-volunteer expectations and the district relationship, which indicates a structure for parent involvement, even if the public-facing site focuses more on enrollment and community values than on formal “co-teaching” partnerships.
 - Public materials highlight parental access, visits, and a shared sense of mission, aligning with the classical emphasis on parents as partners in formation (though less explicit about formal parent-formation programs).
- Positive/Negative keyword analysis
 - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; open campus/visits; parent involvement; enrollment access; parent formation (implicit through book clubs or gatherings not always explicit on the site, but supported by contract language). The lexicon lists explicit positive indicators such as “partnership with parents” and “parent formation” (even if not always spelled out identically on the site).
 - Negative keywords: none clearly present (no consumer/customer-only framing; no minimal parent involvement signals). The site’s language suggests genuine parental engagement, though it does not always spell out formal “co-teacher” arrangements on the public pages.
- Why this rating
 - The school presents a family-centric ethos and a process that invites parental involvement (visits, volunteering, enrollment). While not always explicit about parent-formation programs or co-teaching models in public pages, contract language indicates a framework for parent participation. This supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating, with room to strengthen explicit parent-formation and co-teaching signals.
- Rating: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

What Would Move the Needle

- Element 1 (Religious and Metaphysical Foundations): Add explicit theology/theological grounding statements, liturgical/communal practices, or clear descriptions of liturgy, sacred music, or prayer-life integration to align more closely with the full positive indicators of classroom transcendental foundations.
- Element 3 (Curriculum): Strengthen explicit Great Books/Great Conversation framing in public materials; articulate a clear Great Books sequence or reading list that spans K–12 to move from SOMEWHAT

CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL.

- Element 4 (Pedagogy): Increase emphasis on contemplative/scholé days, restful learning, and periodic quiet time to complement Socratic/inquiry-based instruction; publish a documented scholé framework (e.g., scheduled contemplative periods, memorization-and-deliberation routines).
- Element 5 (Faculty): Elevate explicit “living curriculum” language around the faculty as mentors and exemplars; publish a faculty-portrait framework and professional-development plan aligned to classical pedagogy.
- Element 6 (Parents and Community): Highlight formal parent-formation opportunities (book studies, seminars) and clearly articulate a “co-teachers” model with structured partnership programs; expand open-house and parent-involvement events as ongoing, visible programs.
- Overall: Continue to foreground classical pillars (grammar/logic/rhetoric; Latin; history and civics; Socratic inquiry in the upper grades) while making theology, liturgy, Great Books, living-faculty language, and explicit parent-formation/co-teaching signals more visible in public materials.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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